clearly an infringement on the rights of the states, undermining the federal rights guaranteed by our Constitution.

The second objection is practical. The Constitution rightly speaks of milch and draught cattle. Cows produce milk for about eight years, at which point they are too old for either milch or draught purposes. But they go on to live another eight years. Farmers have to spend large sums of money on their food and fodder requirements and other maintenance costs of a cow, a fortune for agriculturalists who often live barely above subsistence level. This is why they sell non-lactating cows, normally for slaughter. Even our highest courts, despite their variety of views on the matter, have recognised that 'a total ban on [cattle slaughter] was not permissible if, under economic conditions, keeping useless bull or bullock be a burden on the society and therefore not in the public interest.'

India is already home to nearly 512 million cows, according to the 19th National Livestock Census 2012. Aside from maintaining them decently, India would also have to deal with deforestation and over-grazing, as well as the problems caused by abandoned cattle, who stray onto the streets and in many cases die of malnutrition in old age. The previous policy recognised that banning cow slaughter would impose an economic burden on farmers, who, given the paucity of resources at their disposal, would struggle to maintain these animals. As a result, India is or was the largest exporter of buffalo meat in the world—a multi-billion-dollar business. Since the sale and transfer of animals is integral to keep this going, the new rules are likely to severely cripple the meat export, dairy, leather and other allied businesses, which provide employment for over one million individuals within the country, mainly from minority communities. The state of Maharashtra's 2015 beef ban had already destroyed the livelihoods of a million Muslim butchers and truckers in that state; a nationwide ban would push more people into poverty who are currently leading economically productive lives.

Where beef was legally available, it was consumed not just by Muslims and other minorities, but also by a section of Hindus, as a vital source of protein for those who cannot afford other kinds of meat. Statistics suggest that just 2 per cent of the Hindu population consume